

Ron Blomberg: A Dream Comes True in New York

NEW YORK (UPI) — They always called it "The Search" and it's something they've been at, on and off, the past 50 years.

The Giants were looking first. Then the Yankees went seeking the same thing, and finally the Dodgers came along and joined the search — to a degree anyway.

What they all were looking for was "a good Jewish ballplayer." That was the way they always put it, but they were under-stating in a way.

What they really were after wasn't merely a "good" Jewish ballplayer, they wanted a "great" one with whom New York's 2.5 million Jewish population could identify. The Yankees had a crack at the great one, a kid from the Bronx, but Lou Gehrig was playing first base for them at the time and Hank Greenberg decided to go with Detroit instead.

The Giants signed several Jewish ballplayers — Andy Cohen, Harry Danning, Sid Gordon, Phil Weintraub, Harry Feldman and Mike Schermer, the son of an orthodox rabbi. Some were good, some great.

Only the Dodgers turned up a really outstanding one in Sandy Koufax and he never really attained greatness with them until they left Brooklyn for Los Angeles.

New the Yankees seem to have something extra special in Ron Blomberg. He's 22, Jewish, and although the word never is over-used so much as it is in baseball, he could be great.

Ron Blomberg, at the moment, leads the Yanks with a .347 batting average. He also has 19 RBIs and four homers in 41 games and already has caught on with Yankee fans.

"Everybody likes to have a following," says the blond, good-looking, left-handed hitting right fielder. "It makes you feel good to know that people come to see you."

Blomberg, who is from Atlanta, saw Yankee Stadium for the first time two years ago when the Yankees brought him up from Manchester in September.

"I was really scared when I walked into the park," he says. "You know, you always read

about the place, and those monuments out there..." Those monuments he means are in center field and, reading from left to right, they display the sculptured bronze features of such former Yankees as Lou Gehrig, Miller Huggins and Babe Ruth.

"When I'm finished playing, I'd like them to have a monument of mine out there, too," Blomberg says.

Reading that, it may sound presumptuous. The way young Blomberg says it though, it doesn't come out that way. He is not a popoff or a blowhard. He is merely a young man bent on making good at what he's doing. He has been called "a baseball nut."

"I am," he admits cheerfully. "I love coming out here every day."

Some nights it's rough going home though. Like one night last week after he went hitless against the Angels.

Blomberg's wife of 10 months, Mara, was waiting up for him even though it was nearly midnight. She saw immediately he was depressed.

"Don't worry about it," she counseled him, wisely. "You're only human. You can't get a hit every day. Besides, you played pretty good in the field."

But overall, "Boomer" Blomberg has been doing so well that some are reminded of the manner in which Andy Cohen broke in for the Giants here 43 years ago. The New York Times carried an editorial titled a Daniel come to judgment and it said:

"Francis Hogan played well for the Giants in their opening game, but the Hogans have always played good baseball; so have the Kellys and the Caseys, the Dalebents and the Bresnans, and the Wagners and the Zimmermans and the Lazzeris and the Chances. But the Cohens?

"None of their kindfolk has ornamented the professional diamond in New York. Therefore, when Andy Cohen carried off nearly all the honors when the Giants met the Braves Wednesday at the Polo Grounds, there was much more than just a baseball game at stake."

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In the clubhouse after the game, John McGraw, the Giants' manager, told Andy Cohen: "Don't let it turn your head, boy, it's just one ball game."

Andy Cohen never got a big head, but he still returned to the minors two years later.

Funny thing, but when Ron Blomberg left home, his parents told him only one thing.

"Don't ever get a big head," they said.

Ron Blomberg doesn't look like the kind who will. He also looks like the kind who'll be around more than two years.



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New-And Good

Tanner's Chisox Aren't the Same

BALTIMORE (AP) — Chuck Tanner cleaned house after taking over as manager of the Chicago White Sox late last season, then literally started from scratch.

The rebuilding of last season's worst major league team, which lost 106 games, has been swift.

"We've accomplished in one year what some teams hope to accomplish in three years," Tanner said prior to Wednesday night's game against the Baltimore Orioles.

"We have the youngest team in the American League," he said, "and from now on we should maintain our position and keep improving until we're fighting for a pennant."

Tanner began his instant rebuilding program by making wholesale changes, then attacked the attitude of the squad.

"The players actually had to learn how to win," Tanner said. "They had to overcome the feeling of 'Here we go again' every time something went wrong."

Tanner took the White Sox to spring training, "with the assumption that no one knew anything about baseball."

damentals," he said, "but on what to do while you're on the bench before and during a game. It was just like a rookie camp, but I think it has paid off."

The White Sox, with a 63-65 record, already have won six more games than all last season and 66 of their games have been decided by one or two runs.

After Tanner and Roland Hemond, the club's director of player personnel, analyzed the White Sox late last year, Chicago dealt off players with 55 years of major league experience-including Luis Aparicio, Bobby Knoop, Ken Berry and Tom McCraw.

In return, they obtained the likes of Rick Reichardt, Louis Alvarado, Mike Andrews, Jay Johnstone, Pat Kelly, Tom Egan and Tom Bradley.

Then acquisition of Bradley, a 24-year-old right-hander who was 11-1 for Tanner at Hawaii last season in the California Angels' farm system, was one of Tanner's first moves.

Bradley is now 13-11 with a fine 2.76 earned run average, second on the staff only to Wil-